

ECON 339: Behavioral Economics

Final Policy Proposal

Fall 2026

Due Dates

- Problem and Group-Members (if any): Wednesday, October 7
- Behavioral Econ Concepts and Lit Review: Wednesday, October 28
- Solution and Lit Review: Wednesday, November 18
- Final Paper: Wednesday, December 9

Description

The goals of this Final Policy Proposal are for you to:

1. Synthesize your knowledge of behavioral economic concepts.
2. Demonstrate your ability to read/understand academic journal articles in economics.
3. Apply your knowledge of behavioral economics to public policy questions/issues of personal interest.
4. Support economic/policy arguments with economic literature.

The Final Policy Proposal will evaluate you/your group on the basis of these skills. The papers we discuss in class will serve as a good starting point, but an above-average policy proposal (B and above) requires reading, understanding, and citing papers in addition to those we read together in class. All due dates above serve as incentives for you to work on the project gradually, rather than all at once at the end of the semester. While the Problem and Group-Members portion deadline is fixed (so I can ensure all students/groups have a group/problem that makes sense), all other deadlines have a built-in 1 week grace period. The benefit of submitting on-time is you will receive more detailed feedback as to how you might improve these sections before submitting the final draft. If you are having trouble finding a problem to work on, come see me in office/student hours!

Structure of the Final Paper

The Final Policy Proposal should contain the following sections (you are welcome to use these as section headers, but it is not required):

1. Title (the problem you are working on)
2. Authors (list all group members, if any)
3. Description of the Problem.

4. Relevant Behavioral Economic Concepts.
5. The Proposed Policy Solution.
6. References (any citation style).
7. GenAI Usage Report.

All students should submit their own draft as a Word document or pdf file, with double-spaced 12 point font. Note that any paper shorter than 3 pages is unlikely to include the level of detail necessary for a satisfactory grade. I will stop reading at page 8 (not including references).

Description of the Problem

This should be a brief section (approximately 1 page) in which you or your group describe the problem you seek to solve. You might cite newspaper articles or other online sources in this description. Key questions this section should answer include:

- What is the problem?
- Is this program global? Regional? Location-specific?
- What are the current consequences of this problem?
- What solutions have been tried before?
- Have these solutions worked? Why or why not?

Relevant Behavioral Economic Concepts

The goal of this section is to convince me you i) understand behavioral economic concepts from class, ii) have an understanding of which papers (inside and outside class) discuss these concepts, and iii) you can apply these concepts to your specific problem. This section should read like a narrative. For each behavioral economic concept you include, there should be a clearly articulated link to your specific problem supported by appropriately using either in-text or footnote citations.

This section may be short (approximately 0.5 pages to 1 page) depending on the number of concepts. You need to include at least 1 concept from class. You are welcome to include more. However, your grade will be based on how well you link behavioral economic concepts to your specific problem and your use of citations, not the number of concepts you connect to your problem.

The Proposed Policy Solution

In this section, you will describe your proposal for a policy solution. This section should be longer (approximately 2 pages) and answer the following questions:

1. What is your solution?
2. (If applicable): How does it differ from previous solutions?
3. Which behavioral economic concepts/ journal articles support your claims about why this solution will work?
4. What are possible reasons this solution has not been tried before?
5. Are there other implications of implementing this solution?

Again, this should be written as a narrative in which you weave citations and behavioral economic concepts/findings into your answers as to why you think your solution will solve the problem you described in the earlier section.

References

You may use in-text citations or footnotes. The References should be listed after the end of the paper (ideally starting on a new page). You may use any citation style, but each entry must include:

1. Author(s)
2. Title.
3. Year published/current year if working paper.
4. Journal/Working Paper Series where published.
5. If online, link to pdf of the paper.

Final Policy Proposal and ChatGPT/GenAI Usage

With such a final project, GenAI can be a helpful tool if used in a way to help you find papers, refine grammatical structure, and clarify behavioral economic concepts. It should **not** be used to draft arguments, literature reviews, or do the thinking for you!

Remember that you will have to describe/answer questions regarding your Final Policy Proposal without access to notes, so you are responsible the big picture/general ideas from any papers you cite/anything you include in your paper.

GenAI Usage Report

The point of this section is to include any prompts and output you used over the course of the project. **Helpful hint:** In ChatGPT, use the same chat for all project related prompts and submit a single file of all copied-and-pasted prompts and outputs. All group members will submit their own GenAI Usage Report.

If you did not use GenAI for this project in any way (including editing, looking for papers, etc.) simply enter "I did not use GenAI in any way for this project" on a separate sheet.